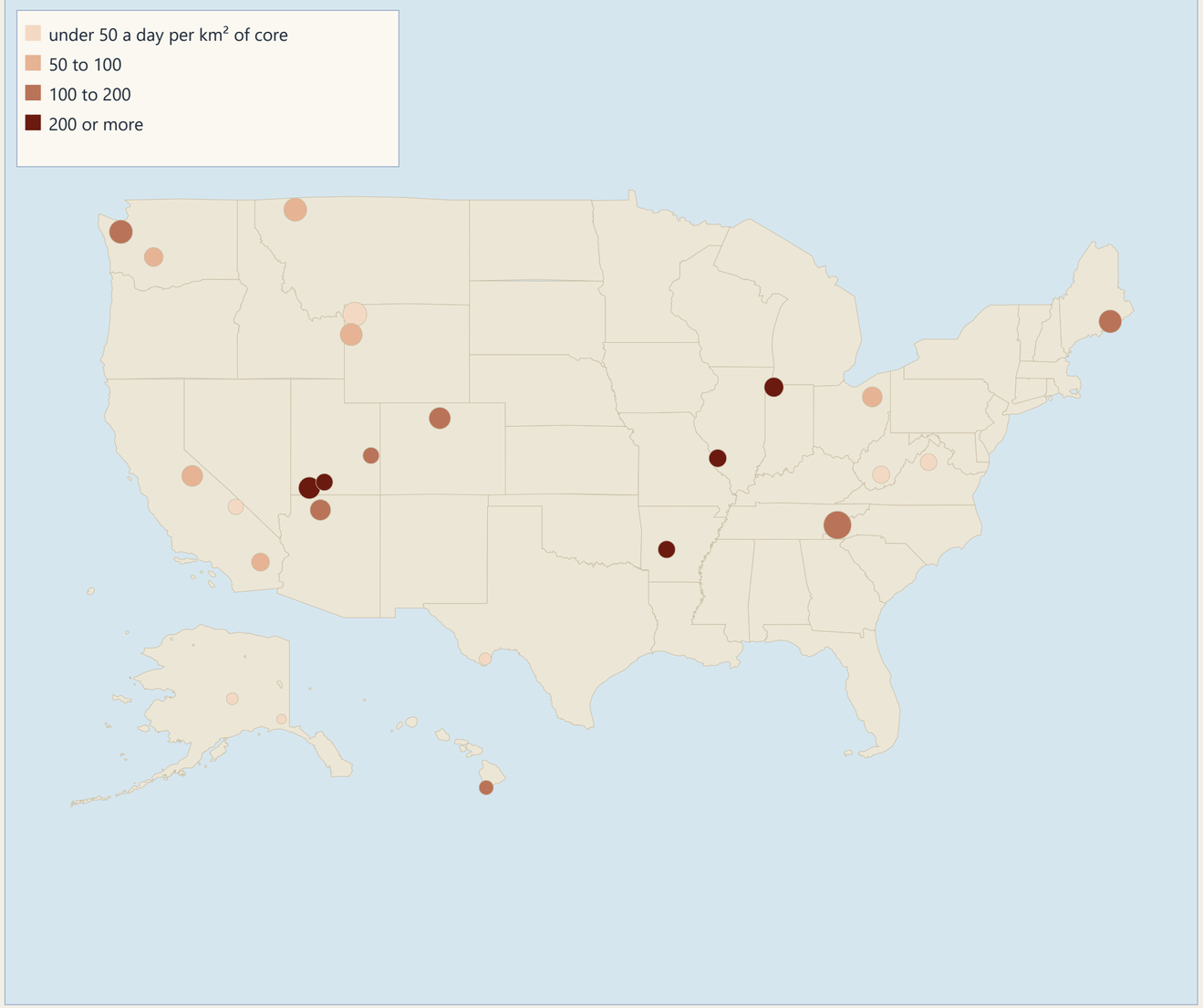
WHERE ARE THE NATIONAL PARKS CROWDED?

The 20 most visited National Parks of 2025 and five contrasts: visits per km² a day over the whole park and in its visitor core (roads, short trails, facilities).

Parks (dot size: visits, 2025)



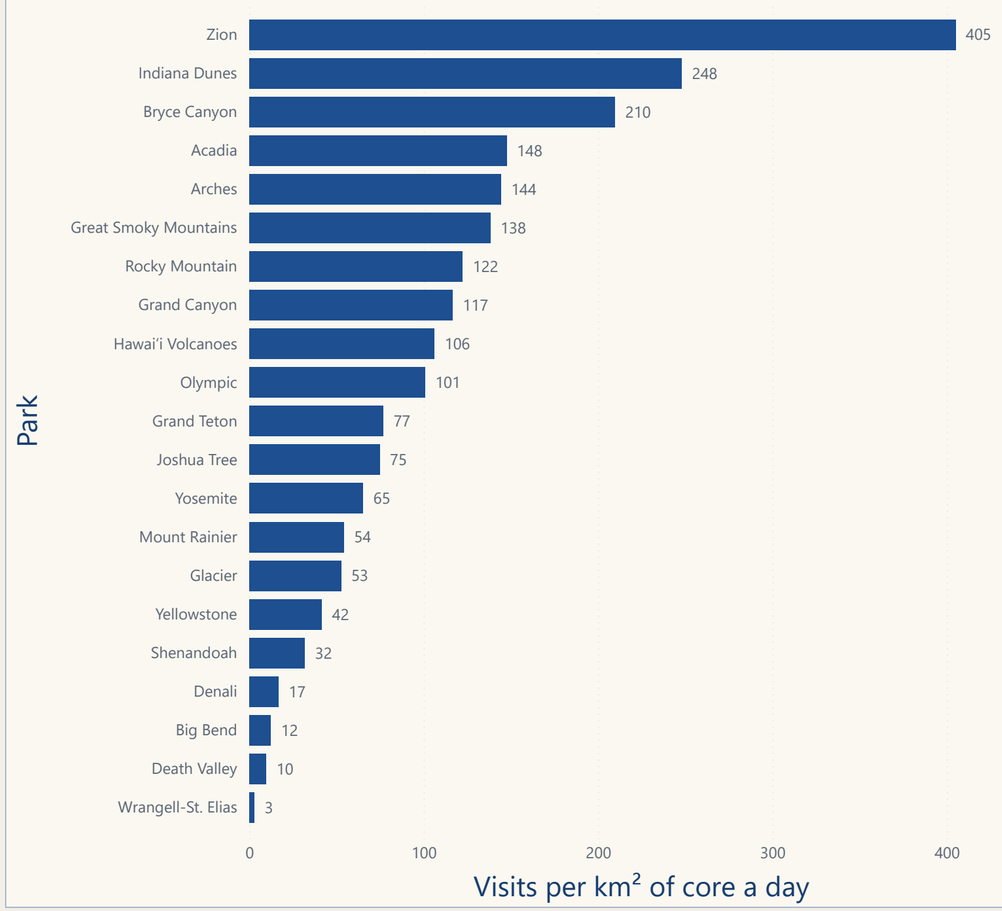
Parks

25

Recreation visits, 2025

75M

Visits per km² of visitor core a day, 2025 (parks with NPS roads)



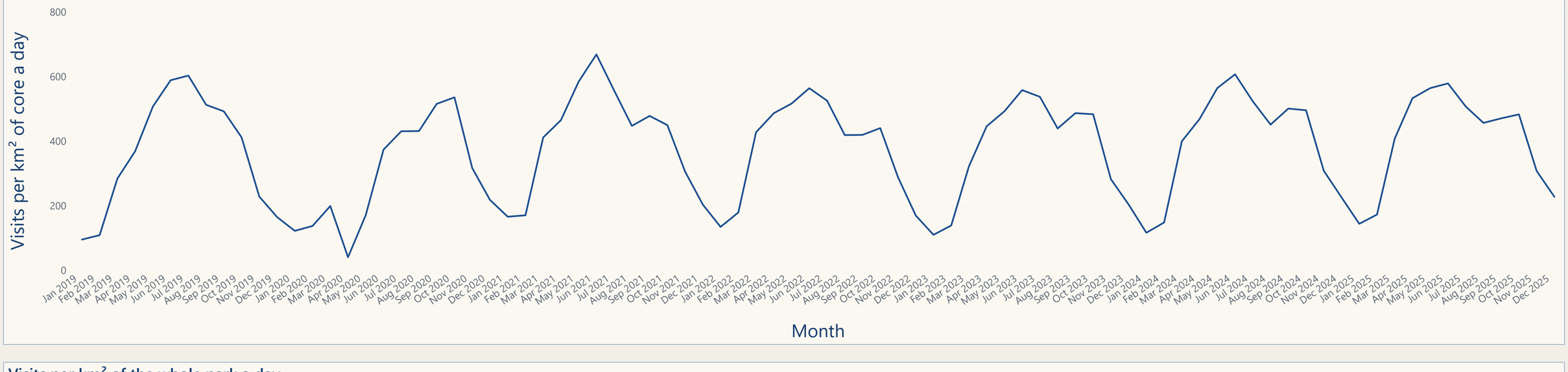
NPS Visitor Use Statistics (irma.nps.gov), NPS boundaries, roads, trails and points of interest. Public domain. Visitor cores drawn by one written rule (Plotlay). Visits are not unique people; counting methods vary by park. Map context: US Census TIGERweb. Made with Plotlay (getplotlay.com).

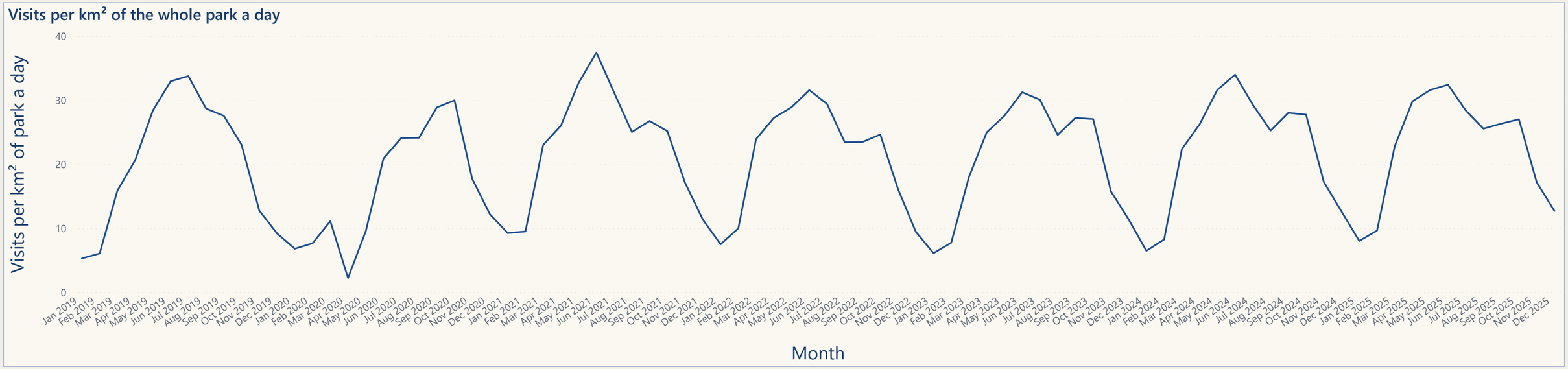
MONTH BY MONTH

Pick a park (it opens on Zion): its visits per km² a day in the core and over the whole park, each month 2019 to 2025.

Park

Zion



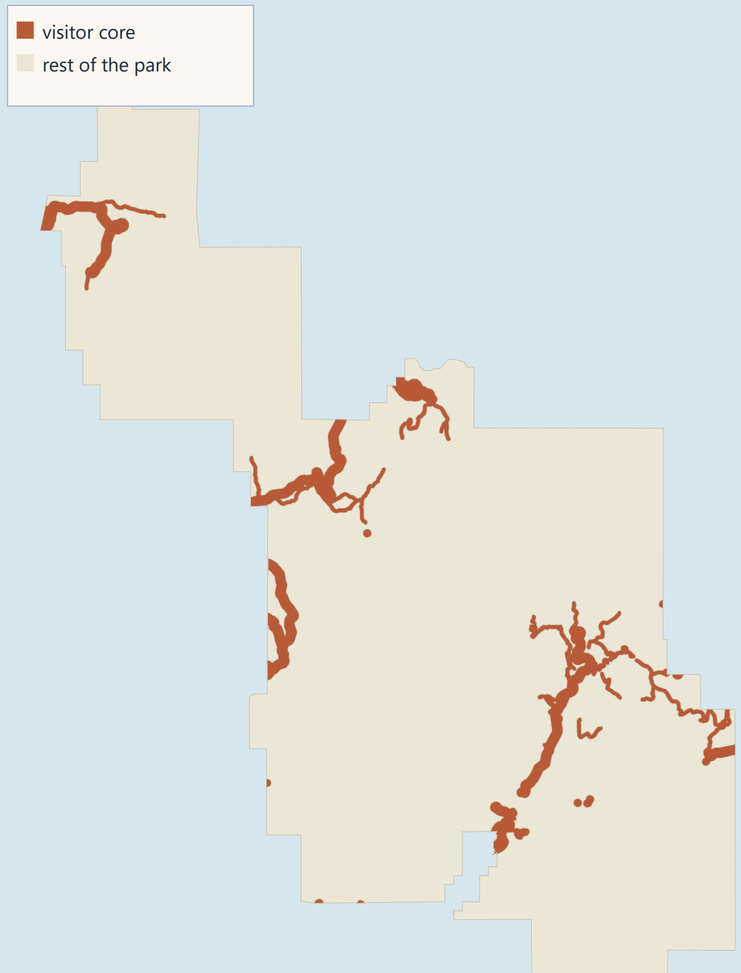


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THE VISITOR CORES

Three parks at their own scale, each core (in colour) inside its park boundary. The rule: 250 m either side of paved park roads, 100 m along trails within 2 km of them, 200 m round visitor facilities.

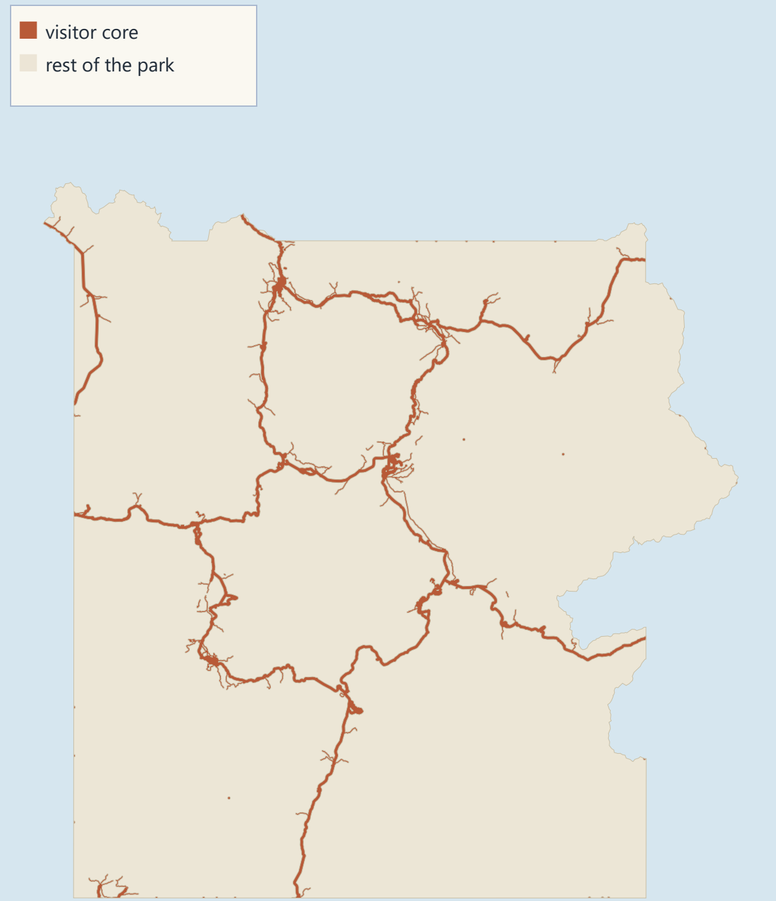
Zion: core 33.7 km² of 602 km²



Great Smoky Mountains: core 228.5 km² of 2,262 km²



Yellowstone: core 313.8 km² of 8,901 km²



NPS Visitor Use Statistics (irma.nps.gov), NPS boundaries, roads, trails and points of interest. Public domain. Visitor cores drawn by one written rule (Plotlay). Visits are not unique people; counting methods vary by park. Map context: US Census TIGERweb. Made with Plotlay (getplotlay.com).

PARK BY PARK

Area, core, 2025 visits and both densities. Roads from: NPS, or Census TIGER where NPS maps no roads (those cores follow every street and read larger).

Parks

Park	State	Park, km²	Core, km²	Core, % of park	Visits, 2025	A day per km² of park	A day per km² of core	Roads from
Gateway Arch	MO	1	0.8	94.9	2,209,028	7,660.9	8,070	Census TIGER
Hot Springs	AR	22	14.7	66.5	2,494,611	309.5	465	Census TIGER
Zion	UT	602	33.7	5.6	4,984,525	22.7	405	NPS
Indiana Dunes	IN	71	29.1	40.8	2,629,497	101.1	248	NPS
Bryce Canyon	UT	146	25.7	17.7	1,967,367	37.0	210	NPS
Acadia	ME	145	75.7	52.1	4,079,318	76.9	148	NPS
Arches	UT	309	28.7	9.3	1,511,740	13.4	144	NPS
Great Smoky Mountains	TN, NC	2,262	228.5	10.1	11,527,939	14.0	138	NPS
Rocky Mountain	CO	1,081	93.5	8.7	4,171,431	10.6	122	NPS
Grand Canyon	AZ	4,869	104.1	2.1	4,430,653	2.5	117	NPS
Hawai'i Volcanoes	HI	1,557	48.5	3.1	1,877,854	3.3	106	NPS
Olympic	WA	3,717	97.5	2.6	3,584,187	2.6	101	NPS
Cuyahoga Valley	OH	136	100.7	74.3	3,025,325	61.2	82	Census TIGER
Grand Teton	WY	1,255	135.6	10.8	3,800,648	8.3	77	NPS
Joshua Tree	CA	3,227	107.5	3.3	2,932,644	2.5	75	NPS
Yosemite	CA	3,026	179.6	5.9	4,278,413	3.9	65	NPS
Mount Rainier	WA	957	82.6	8.6	1,635,342	4.7	54	NPS
Glacier	MT	4,080	163.3	4.0	3,136,557	2.1	53	NPS
New River Gorge	WV	290	120.7	41.6	1,958,440	18.5	45	Census TIGER
Yellowstone	WY, MT, ID	8,901	313.8	3.5	4,762,988	1.5	42	NPS
Shenandoah	VA	799	144.5	18.1	1,682,152	5.8	32	NPS
Denali	AK	24,389	89.0	0.4	543,300	0.1	17	NPS
Big Bend	TX	3,282	126.0	3.8	568,104	0.5	12	NPS
Death Valley	CA, NV	13,901	373.5	2.7	1,320,134	0.3	10	NPS
Wrangell-St. Elias	AK	53,337	103.1	0.2	108,840	0.0	3	NPS

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